

A FOOL AT THE STOCK EXCHANGE

I MADE MY TRIP IN THE MIDDLE OF WINTER, LATE FEBRUARY 1986. By now I expected to have made enough paper profit to afford a room at the Plaza Hotel on Central Park South, but given the circumstances, I sublet an empty apartment on Ninety-sixth Street from a friend who charged a merciful monthly rate. Instead of the Burberry coat I'd hoped to purchase, I came up with a five-dollar thrift-shop cashmere. The moth holes were scarcely visible except in direct light. I consoled myself with the thought that soon I'd be surrounded with firsthand knowledge of the kind that the average investor only dreams about, and this could only improve my fortunes.

Avoiding an expensive cab, I took the Lexington Avenue subway downtown. The general appearance of the riders improved at each successive stop, until only the people wearing recently dry-cleaned Burberrys, carrying unscarred briefcases, and reading the *Wall Street Journal* were left. At the Wall Street stop, they all got off in a clump, and I followed.

Still below ground, we trudged past a glass display case that tells the story of the stock market. I paused to consider the details, causing a minor traffic jam, and a few curses were hurled in my direction. I ignored these and read on. Here it confirmed that our earliest investors bought Revolutionary War bonds. These war bonds, along with the first stocks, were traded in coffeehouses and under the trees along Wall Street. It sounded like the stock exchange did start out as a flea market and might have continued in that way except that the brokers decided to organize. The pioneer brokers wrote up a Buttonwood Agreement, a sort of Wall Street